In accordance with the purposes and principles enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations, the Department of Peacekeeping Operations (DPKO) has been established to assist the member states and the Secretary-General in their efforts to maintain international peace and security. The DPKO plans, prepares, manages and directs UN peacekeeping operations so that they can effectively fulfill their mandates under the overall authority of the Security Council and General Assembly, and under the command vested in the Secretary-General.

DPKO provides political and executive directions to UN peacekeeping operations, and maintains contact with the Security Council, troop and financial contributors, and parties to the conflict in the implementation of the Security Council mandates. The Department works to integrate the efforts of UN, and governmental and non-governmental entities in the context of peacekeeping operations. Peacekeeping operations may consist of several components, including a military component, which may or may not be armed, and various civilian components encompassing a broad range of disciplines. The chief concerns are to alleviate human suffering, and create conditions and build institutions for self-sustaining peace. Depending on their mandate, peacekeeping missions may be required to:

- Deploy to prevent the outbreak of conflict or the spill-over of conflict across borders.
- Stabilize conflict situations after a ceasefire, to create an environment for the parties to reach a lasting peace agreement.
- Assist in implementing comprehensive peace agreements.
- Lead states or territories through a transition to stable government, based on democratic principles, good governance and economic development.

List of UN Peacekeeping Operations (1948–2008)	
UNTSO	United Nations Truce Supervision Organization (from May 1948 till present)